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Plato's Myths of Judgement

JULIA ANNAS

I

The myths in Plato's dialogues have been in general neglected by philosophers; when he moves from argument or exposition into the myth form there is a sharp switching-off of philosophical interest. There have been studies of the myths,¹ some of them from a philosophical perspective, but it is broadly true that philosophical analyses of the dialogues have made little or no attempt to relate the content of each myth to the argument of the dialogue in which it occurs. Whether they feel respect for the myths as attempts to express profound truths beyond reason's grasp, or feel contempt for them as holidays from serious thinking, or (most commonly) feel uncomfortable with them and endorse Crombie's, "To me these myths tremble between the sublime and the tedious",² philosophers have mostly not thought to include the myths as part of "Plato's thought".³

This is a pity, for some of the myths at least are worth non-literary study, and this is especially true of the long and elaborate eschatological myths of the *Gorgias*, *Phaedo* and *Republic*. All three myths come at the end of a major dialogue full of controversial claims about the right way to live, and impassioned rejections of conventional beliefs about good and evil, and what is in one's interests. In this context an eschatological myth about the ultimate fate of the good and the bad can hardly fail to be relevant to the dialogue's main moral argument, and may well be revealing about the form of that argument, and any appeal in it to the agent's interests. To treat such a myth as an optional extra for those who like stories is to risk missing something of significance about the form of Plato's arguments, as well as interesting contrasts between dialogues; for differences between two myths may point to differences in what the dialogues are arguing, or may illustrate a major shift of emphasis.

The philosophical myth mixes genres, and so is disliked by philosophers who want philosophy to be "professional", with its own uniform and distinct medium, preferably as transparent as possible so that philosophical argument cannot be confused with more literary modes of persuading. We can find this attitude in Aristotle, who faults the *Phaedo* myth by reading it literally and then complaining that its geography and hydraulics are impossible. The account of Tartarus, he says, makes nonsense of the way rivers flow, and of the phenomenon of rain; and anyway it

just is obvious that rivers flow into the sea and not down some great hole in the earth to Tartarus (*Meteorologica* II, 335b33-336a33.) Aristotle was, I suspect, as aware as we are that this could be thought an inappropriate criticism; he is polemically refusing to take the *Phaedo* myth seriously in its own terms by treating it as a failed geography lesson.

Aristotle's attitude here is only an extreme version of the attitude that treats the myths as quarries for accounts of geography and technology, religious beliefs, literary tropes – anything but an integral part of a philosophical dialogue. Yet this fails to answer adequately to what Plato is doing in mixing his genres. A philosophical, as opposed to a popular myth, *should* have some rational interpretation.

One reason why this has not been more attempted is that the contrast between myth and argument has been understood too crudely. If myth is a sharply demarcated alternative to rational procedures, then anything goes: myth is then amenable solely to unanalytic appreciation, “aesthetic” in the pejorative sense. Taking the myths to be Plato's lapses from rational thinking encourages passively uncritical reading of them. Hence a tendency to assimilate myths that look superficially alike, as the eschatological myths have been assimilated to one another and to the Christian Last Judgement myth. Elements in different myths have likewise been conflated. There are “divine shepherds” in the myths of both the *Critias* and the *Statesman*, but, as Christopher Gill has pointed out,⁴ it is wrong to use this to assimilate the myths; when myths have (as these do) different political messages, the elements in them are being put to distinct uses.

A crude dichotomy of myth and reason encourages us also to stay content with unhelpful interpretations of the myths. Thus the frequent appearance in the myths of reincarnation is explained by Plato's having picked up the idea from some Pythagoreans. Whatever the value of this as a historical explanation – relevant pre-Platonic evidence being hard to come by – it leaves all the important questions still open: for why did Plato choose to pick up *this* idea from the Pythagoreans? If myths have no rational interpretation, we can only say that the idea had some personal appeal. But surely we should be asking what Plato uses this notion to *do*: what idea is of importance to him for which reincarnation would seem to be the right symbolic expression?

Plato's myths are often ignored or downgraded because it is thought that he takes all myths, including his own, to be mere *mythoi* or stories, which are all to be despised by contrast with *logoi* or rational discourse and argument. This is, however, too simple. *Mythos* and cognate words originally mean no more than “speech”,⁵ and the usage survives in Plato

whereby *mythoi* and *logoi* are put together and both are opposed to action (e.g. *Republic* 376d9-10). By Plato's time *mythos* has come to mean something like "story"; to favour *mythoi* over *logoi* is to favour storytelling over argument. Given his stress on the importance of reason in our lives, it is not surprising that we can often find Plato displaying a general hostility to stories, and it is not hard to find passages where he abuses or despises (mere) stories as trivial, suitable only for children or lightweight entertainment.⁶ He is especially hostile to the stories that we think of as traditional "Greek myths"; *Republic* books 2 and 3 attack them as immoral and misleading, and he insists that they should not be allegorized or explained in terms of physical theory; he refuses to find rational depth in them.⁷

But this hostility or indifference concerns the content of particular stories. Plato nowhere says or implies that there is a single all-purpose distinction between storytelling and reasoning such that all stories are necessarily stupid or immoral. He in fact clearly believes that some *mythoi*, stories, do have rational depth. The fact that popular stories are mostly trivial does not prevent the philosopher from using or inventing a story which is not.⁸ Thus we sometimes find Plato indifferent as to whether his account is called a *mythos* or a *logos*;⁹ the *Timaeus*' cosmology is called a "likely *mythos*";¹⁰ and the *Republic*'s account of the growth of the state is called a *mythos*, though it clearly displays the rational basis for political association.¹¹ In the case of his own "mythical" stories Plato, so far from contrasting myth and reason, emphasizes both the obvious fact that we have a story, not an argument, and the less obvious fact that it is a *seriously meant* story: it is foolish to treat it as an old wives' tale.¹² In fact he goes so far as to claim that the "myth of Atlantis" is *true*;¹³ and the *Gorgias* myth is introduced by, and interspersed with, claims that it is true, and a *logos*.¹⁴ We have, then, no good grounds for assuming that Plato thought his own philosophical myths trivial, or a dispensable part of the dialogues.¹⁵

Plato has, or course, a well-known epistemological problem over his myths. He uses the myth form to express truths that are profound and important; yet for him myth or any form of storytelling has low epistemological status, the preferred philosophical method being argument. (There is a similar problem in his use of imagery, as in the *Republic*'s Sun, Line and Cave sequence.) It is, clearly, a mistake to make Plato's myths or imagery central to interpreting his thought, at the expense of the arguments; to make this use of the more accessible passages would be unplatonicly lazy and unphilosophical. But it is also a mistake to ignore the myths (or images) as being clearly dispensable. For Plato, his use of philosophically

low-grade forms to present important philosophical content produces a *problem*, a problem which he never explicitly solves, but which is inescapably obvious to an author who has chosen to do philosophy in a literary medium. The mixed genre of the philosophical myth is of its nature problematic (and its interpretation exposed to much uncertainty). But the easy modern assumption that myths can be ignored on the grounds that they “do not lend themselves to logical analysis”¹⁶ may be congenial to our own view of the relation of myth to reason, but it fails Plato; it solves his problem by trivializing it. For him, as for Aristotle, “the lover of myth is a lover of wisdom, *in a way*” (*Metaphysics* 982b18-19).

These programmatic remarks are meant to give some basis to the following discussion of Plato’s three myths of judgement after death in the *Gorgias*, *Phaedo* and *Republic*. I shall examine each one in the context of its dialogue and discuss its relation to what has been argued in that dialogue about the kind of reason we already have in this life for pursuing virtue. The result will show, I hope, that what look superficially like very similar myths give us very different pictures of what judgement after death brings. And these are reflections of differences in what the dialogues have argued; from the *Gorgias* through the *Phaedo* to the *Republic* we are given different kinds of reason for being virtuous in this life.

II

The *Gorgias* myth is the simplest, and the one which makes the most straightforward use of popular and traditional religious imagery. There is a judgement after death; the good are rewarded and the bad punished. This basic idea is put forward as a received popular view, as it probably was (we find Cephalus holding it at *Republic* 330d-331b). But Plato is not copying any single source, but synthesizing various elements in his own way.¹⁷

One reason Plato has for picking on and elaborating the idea of a *judgement* after death is of course the fact that the *Gorgias* presents Socrates as defending the way of life which all the dialogue’s readers know brought him to trial and execution; running through the whole dialogue has been the constant theme that Socrates will be tried for his life and, as things are in this world, will be condemned.¹⁸ The trial after death will reverse wrong judgements made in trials in this life, and, as Socrates explicitly points out (526e1-527a4), there the positions of Calicles and himself will be reversed. The extraordinary prominence given in this myth to the judges, and to the details of their judging, serves in the context of the *Gorgias* as a whole to stress the idea of a final rectification: Socrates exemplifies the good man who suffers undeservedly here at the hands of

incompetent judges, but will be rewarded hereafter by judges who are truly impartial and better-informed. Socrates is thus shown as encouraged by the myth; whatever is done to him by the Athenian judges (and of course the reader knows what that was) will be put right by the true judges after death.

The *Gorgias* myth, then, expresses a kind of optimism: we should not be depressed by the fact that around us we plainly see the good suffering and the wicked flourishing, for this is not the end of the matter; ultimately there will be a judgement where everyone gets what they deserve. Sidgwick articulates very clearly, in a well-known passage, the role played in moral thinking by this demand that there be another world rectifying the moral inadequacies of this one, and guaranteeing that a commitment to morality will ultimately reward the individual agent. “. . . [T]he whole system of our beliefs as to the intrinsic reasonableness of conduct must fall, without a hypothesis unverifiable by experience reconciling the Individual with the Universal Reason, without a belief, in some form or other, that the moral order which we see imperfectly realized in this actual world is yet actually perfect. If we reject this belief, we may perhaps still find in the non-moral universe an adequate object for the Speculative Reason, capable of being in some sense ultimately understood. But the Cosmos of Duty is thus really reduced to a Chaos; and the prolonged effort of the human intellect to frame a perfect ideal of rational conduct is seen to have been foredoomed to inevitable failure”.¹⁹

Plato expresses the conviction that justice will ultimately bring reward to the just by refining, quite explicitly, the crude outlines of the traditional stories. Originally, he says, bad judgements were made because the judges were misled by false appearances (523b4-d5); so Zeus reforms the system. Now they are to judge not outer achievements and status but the person's inner condition; they are to strip off the clothes and judge the naked soul. And the souls are judged on the basis of the state they are in, wicked souls being scarred and twisted. The primitive demand that there be a judgement that finally puts right wrongs that have been done here has been made more subtle and profound by the point that what is judged is not what you have achieved but rather the kind of person that you are.

This myth is of all the three the only one at all like the Christian myth in being a *last* judgement, which settles the fate of each person once and for all. (The Christian judgement is of course last in a further sense, namely that it happens at the end of the world.) In the *Gorgias* there are no roads back from Tartarus or the Isles of the Blessed. Justice, once done, stays done. Hence the rewards and punishments after death, as in the Christian

myth, form a real incentive to be just now. We can read the myth literally or we can demythologize it, taking it as claiming that the unjust person is being punished now in having a scarred soul; the basic claim is still that rewards and punishments on earth are not the last word, but are ultimately, at some deeper level, rectified in accordance with justice, so that it is not really in your interests to be unjust, even if on the obvious worldly level you are flourishing now.

The fact that the judgement is a *last* judgement is relevant to its status as a threat to the wicked who manipulate earthly judgements. The whole point of the myth is the contrast between what seems, now, to be the end (death, possibly an unjust death like Socrates') and what really is the case on a deeper level (the mythical events which will take place after death). This powerful contrast, which is put to such emotional use, could only be weakened by the thought that this judgement did not prescribe the soul's final fate at all, that it was only one episode in a larger pattern. The *Gorgias* does not look beyond the single contrast of judgements here and the final morally rectifying judgement.

The finality of the judgement has been questioned, most sharply by Dodds,²⁰ who claims that the *Gorgias* myth presupposes the doctrine of reincarnation, though it is not openly stated. The matter is of some importance to my argument, so I shall look at Dodds' main argument, which is that at 525b-d Plato says that the incurably wicked are punished in Tartarus, not for their own sakes like the curable, but as examples, hung up in the prisonhouse as dreadful warnings. But who can benefit by these examples? asks Dodds. They are unavailable to the living, and "for the dead the lesson comes, one would suppose, too late". So, "the passage makes sense only on the assumption that these dead will one day return to earth" (p. 381).

I agree here with Irwin (p. 248) that the passage makes perfect sense without assuming that the lessons the dead learn are to be applied in another life. Plato has already insisted on the power of punishment to cure wickedness (477e-481b). He needs a justification for punishing those who are agreed to be incurable; that their punishment will help the curable be cured is a sufficient justification, and it is inappropriately literal-minded to press any further the question, what happens to these curables who are cured. There is no answer within the myth in the form and to the extent that Plato has developed it.

The *Gorgias* myth, then, does not presuppose reincarnation; we do not need to locate the rationale of punishing the incurably wicked dead in future lives on earth. And reincarnation would not even fit in; the whole

point of the *Gorgias* myth, as we have seen, is the simple idea that our trials and judgements in this life (and especially Socrates') are not the end; there is a final morally rectifying judgement, unapparent in this world, where rewards come to the just and punishments to the wicked.

The myth, then, is giving us a consequentialist reason to be just. Whether we take it as really threatening future punishment for wrongdoing, or demythologize its message as the claim that being wicked brings the punishment of a scarred and deformed soul now, its message is still that justice pays "in the end", on a deeper level than we can now see. The final judgement myth is a myth of moral optimism; being good will benefit you, if not now then "in the end", in some more profound way than is recognized by Athenian judges. And this is the moral message that Socrates has been defending throughout the *Gorgias*: justice is really the best bet, though worldly wisdom fails to see this.

If we accept this morally optimistic claim, then we can see that we *do* have reason to be just; the wicked person is simply short-sighted, failing to perceive the massive mistake that he or she is making in risking hell-fire for the sake of a few advantages now. Even Cephalus is capable of grasping that message. The trouble is that, as Sidgwick stresses, we don't seem to have any very convincing basis for the moral optimism. Theists can perhaps accept such a morally last judgement as implied by the existence of an omnipotent and benevolent God. But without such a belief the myth will indeed strike someone like Callicles as being just an old wives' tale, something that would be morally significant, if it were true, but dependent on a hypothesis that we have no good reason to believe. The *Gorgias* is, notoriously, the dialogue in which Socrates' claims that justice pays are found least convincing by his interlocutors, and are least adequately supported by his arguments. It may not be an unconnected fact that the *Gorgias* myth is both the most religiously coloured and the starkest in the claim it makes that justice pays *in the end*.

III

At first sight the *Phaedo* myth appears to be giving basically the same judgement story as the *Gorgias*, with the addition only of a lot of tedious whimsy. But in fact it is a confused and confusing myth, and its message is blurred.

As in the *Gorgias*, souls are judged after death, and they are rewarded or punished according to their state of goodness or badness. But in the *Phaedo* there are several shifts of emphasis which together downgrade the role of the judging. (This may be connected to the fact that the dialogue is much

more concerned with Socrates' death than with his actual trial.) There is a great deal of stress on the soul's degree of ease in leaving the body and "travelling" from it before it even gets to being judged (107d5-108c8). The judgement and the judges are very cursorily mentioned, in striking contrast to the *Gorgias* (107d8, 113d3-4, 114b5-6). And there is a new stress on the souls' relations to one another; those who commit grave crimes can only be freed from their suffering when their victims allow it (113e6-114b6).

One other obvious change is the insertion of a long chunk of fanciful cosmology. This can hardly be a display of learning, since there is no learning, only fantasy; but we can discern a serious purpose. Plato is trying to get beyond the primitive religious imagery of the *Gorgias*. Heaven and hell are no longer places outside our world; rather, they are parts of our world when that is seen for what it really is rather than from our present limited viewpoint. What we call the world, we are told, is only one lowly part of a vast universe, in which Tartarus is really the underground source of rivers and the Isles of the Blessed are really just islands nearer than us to the upper air (111a). Plato is reinterpreting traditional beliefs in a different way; instead of being described in the language of myth and poetry, Tartarus and the Isles of the Blessed are firmly made part of our actual world. They are not, of course, seen to be parts of our world as we normally go about studying it — hence the ineptness of Aristotle's criticisms — but they can be seen as such from the viewpoint of the philosopher, the person with true understanding of how the universe and its various components really are.²¹

This cosmological transposition of the idea of judgement after death is unexpected, but so far consistent with what we have seen before. But there is also another, new strand of thought in the *Phaedo*, one which has large consequences for the judgement myth.

Running through the dialogue has been the thought that soul and body are sharply distinct and opposed. In fact Plato notoriously wavers, between different arguments, in his treatment of the soul/body relation and the nature of the soul; but in Socrates' extended discussions of the philosopher's attitude to the soul and the body (64a-69e) and their respective affinities (78b-84b) he develops the idea that excellence for a soul lies in separation from the body and defectiveness in attachment to the body and commitment to its concerns. In this context he describes the good soul as parting easily from the body at death, while the bad soul lingers on round it, and because of its desire for embodiment is compelled to re-enter other bodies again, of a kind appropriate to its former life (80d5-82c8). Reincarnation thus appears as a punishment for a bad life, and the highest

kind of virtue is said to belong to the philosopher, who by refusing to identify with the body's concerns renders his soul at death "pure", unattracted by the body and presumably not liable to reincarnation.

It is true that in the only passage where reincarnation explicitly figures the treatment of it is ironical; various types of people are reincarnated as appropriate animals. But this is no reason to minimize Plato's commitment to the idea.²² He is deadly serious in his repeated insistence that the best fate for a soul is permanent escape from the body, and that being returned to a body is appropriate as a punishment. He is ironical in his sketch of the fates of various kinds of people; but he refers back to this passage in all apparent seriousness later in the myth (108a8), something which indicates that for him reincarnation is not a crackpot personal belief but an appropriate expression of important truths about the relation of soul and body in the individual person.

Reincarnation has made its way right into the myth too. Firstly Plato repeats that good souls will part easily from the body, while the bad will have a harder time (108a6-c5). Secondly, there is a way out of Hades now, as well as an entrance; the myth begins by saying that souls are guided back when they have suffered what is appropriate (107d5-e4). This leads us to expect that reward and punishment after death will consist in appropriate reincarnations. But in fact this idea has not been grafted successfully on to the basic judgement myth. The development of the judgement idea, in fact, becomes very unclear in this myth. We begin with souls going to Hades and returning after appropriate treatment, in a context that strongly suggests that the punishment is the reincarnation attaching soul to a new body. But then we move on to the cosmologically transposed version of the judgement myth, and find quite a different set of ideas: now souls are judged and then rewarded or punished not in another life here but in the afterlife there, not by appropriate reincarnation but more traditionally, by torture in hell or bliss in heaven.

No way is offered, in the *Phaedo*, to reconcile these different sets of ideas; we must conclude, I think, that reincarnation and the final judgement myth have not been successfully combined. The final morally rectifying judgement is still there, together with vivid pictures of the afterlife; and they are unreconciled with the idea that the only appropriate punishment for bad souls is rebirth into another body. The lack of fit shows up sharply at 114c2-6. There, good souls are described as being rewarded by living in a heaven, while those completely purified by philosophy will live forever without bodies "and go to dwellings even more beautiful than these". The philosopher, with complete detachment from the body, is

aiming at escape from reincarnation; and this presupposes that those less perfect are rewarded, but are still not free from being reincarnated. The picture that this demands is the one we find in the *Phaedrus* myth:²³ there is a cycle of reincarnations, in which the quality of each life improves or worsens the next life that the soul gets; and the height of achievement is that of the philosopher who is finally released from the cycle and disembodied for ever. But in the *Phaedo* Plato lacks the apparatus to make this point properly; he has to fit it into the myth of judgement and the afterlife, and it fits very badly. If the philosophers' reward is final disembodiment, then the Isles of the Blessed, the second-best reward of the non-philosophical good, will have to represent some kind of embodiment. Yet this has been put forward as a repulsive punishment, whereas the Isles of the Blessed must symbolize some afterlife reward. Further, to bring in the philosophers' reward in terms of their going to some place "still better" leaves us looking in vain for some place to put them within what we have been told is the *whole* universe described to us so far. (Burnet in his note on this passage suggests, following Stewart, that "we are to think, perhaps, of the natal stars of the *Timaeus*." This shows the insolubility of the problem in the myth's own terms. There is nowhere, in the universe described in this myth, for these "still better" places to be.) The afterlife judgement and reincarnation simply do not fit together, in this myth.

The *Gorgias* myth, I claimed, was the expression of the morally optimistic idea that justice will "in the end" reward the agent; what effect is produced on this message by the *Phaedo*'s confusing interjection of the belief in reincarnation?

The way Socrates both introduces and rounds off the myth suggests that its role is the same as that of the *Gorgias* myth. If the soul is immortal, we are told, we should take great care (107c2), since the risk we run is terrible (c4); it would be better for the wicked if death were the end, but in fact being good is the only refuge from evil and the only safe course (c5-d2). When Socrates prepares to die, he is confident, and this can only be because he takes himself (self-righteously, to our minds) to be the fully good person who can expect rewards (114d1-115a1).²⁴ I cannot agree with Gallop here (pp. 222-3) that Plato is not appealing to the consequences of justice and that the myth is consistent with a defence of justice that is independent of afterlife rewards and punishments. Whether heaven and hell are located in our futures or are regarded as reward and punishment now, they are consequences of virtue and wickedness. Gallop claims that Plato "implies that wickedness is burdensome in itself, whatever may happen after death." However, the punishments in Tartarus described at

such length certainly represent the upshot of wickedness rather than the state of being wicked; for one thing, they crucially involve the reactions of other people. If we take them seriously – if we think that the myth answers to something real – then they give us a reason to be just which is clearly consequentialist: if *that* is what wickedness leads to “in the end”, then it is surely to be avoided.

The introduction of reincarnation, however, blurs this message. For it removes the finality of the morally rectifying judgement. And the passage at 81e-82b, ironical though it is, raises worries. Why should I be deterred from injustice by the thought that my soul will be reincarnated in a wolf? If I were to be aware of being a wolf, and regret having brought this about (as presumably I am to be aware of, and regret having brought about, the punishment in Tartarus) then it would be a disincentive; but nothing in the *Phaedo* suggests that there is continuity of consciousness between reincarnations. The soul which will survive death is, it is true, consistently thought of as being the self, the (real) person; but this gives no grounds for thinking that the experiences of different incarnations can be simultaneously available to the same self. The thought that what happens to me after death is but one stage in a continuing process of which I will not be conscious (any more than I am now) can only weaken the force of the final judgement myth. That appealed to the idea that I should be just now because of consequences after death of which I shall be all too conscious. The thought that if I die wicked I will become a wolf could, of course, function as a non-rational kind of deterrence; the repellent image may achieve the desirable result of frightening me into good behaviour now. But Plato is not to be satisfied merely with behaviour that conforms to what is right out of fear without rational defence; and it is clearly unsatisfactory if the deterrent thought is actually an illogical one.

In the *Phaedo*, then, Plato is pulled in two ways; but we do not yet see fully the moral significance of the idea of reincarnation. It does not yet suggest an *alternative* to the final morally rectifying judgement. We are not yet told that there is a *cycle* of reincarnations, or that the soul's return to the body is part of an endless process. And (relatedly, as we shall see) although destiny and necessity make an entrance (107e3, 108c2, 113a3, 115a2-3, 5-6) they are not yet centre stage.

IV

The Myth of Er in the *Republic* is the most striking and famous of the three judgement myths; it is more complex than the *Gorgias* myth, without being confused and eccentric like the *Phaedo* myth. It raises puzzles as to its

message, however; not because of tensions within the myth, but because of tensions between the myth itself and its frame. In his introduction to it, Socrates appears to be saying firmly that the afterlife rewards and punishments that the myth describes are further consequences of justice and injustice. For, after having completed the defence of justice promised, namely showing it to be worthwhile even to the possessor of Gyges' ring (612a8-b5) he then concedes that the just person will in fact have all the good consequences that justice is generally allowed to bring, both good reputation etc., in this world, and the immeasurably greater rewards after death (614a5-6). The myth, then, appears quite openly to be offering us a consequentialist reason to be just; and this suggestion is reinforced by the very financially-minded summing-up at the end: if we believe the myth, Socrates says, then we shall be dear to ourselves and to the gods both here and when we pick up the prizes for being just, like the winners in the games collecting theirs (621c7-d1).

What we expect, then, is a repetition of the moral optimism of the other myths: justice will be seen to pay after the final morally rectifying judgement. But in this dialogue, such a conception would raise a severe problem: for the *Republic* is highly self-conscious about the way in which justice should and should not be defended, and insists that it is to be put not in the class of things wanted for their consequences, but in the "fairest" of the three classes (357b-358a), namely good things that are desirable because of what they are of their own nature, as well as because of what they bring with them. What then can be the point of claiming that justice will bring rewards, whether in the short run or in heaven, when such a claim would put it in the wrong class, of things wanted for their consequences?

It will be retorted that there is no real problem here, because the book 10 considerations are explicitly tacked on; there is nothing odd about showing that justice is worth having for what it is and for its consequences, and then adding, as a final clincher, the point that it also has some good consequences that one might not have thought of. But this is to underestimate the problem. At the beginning of book 2, where Socrates undertakes to show that justice is to be welcomed both for itself and for its consequences, he strictly excludes *some* consequences. These are the conventional rewards and reputations that attach to justice in society as it is, and they are excluded because they are no guide to the truth about justice (367b1-6, d3-e1). When these are restored in book 10, then we get a shock: to claim that justice really is the best bet in terms of humanly recognizable external success is to make a claim which was explicitly ruled out as being irrelevant to the main argument. (If you find it convincing, you will not feel the need

for the deeper argument that has occupied nine books of the *Republic*; hence it undercuts, rather than adds to, that argument.) And since the myth's heavenly rewards are clearly bracketed with the conventional rewards in life, as being considerations of a type hitherto ruled out of the argument, it looks as though the myth of Er is giving us an incentive to be just which the main argument of the dialogue has condemned as being beside the point.

Many readers of the *Republic* have thus been repelled by the myth as a lapse from the level of the main moral argument.²⁵ This thought is supported by the many other indications that book 10 is a later addition imperfectly harmonized with the rest of the dialogue. However, to regard the myth in this way is, I now think, to neglect its content, to assume that its message is in essence the same as those of the *Gorgias* and *Phaedo*. If, however, we examine carefully what the myth says, we find a rather different message, and one more consonant with what the *Republic* has argued about justice. There is still, of course, the problem of why Plato frames the myth with comments that suggest that its message is the familiar optimistic claim that justice will pay you in the end; we cannot get away from the fact that book 10 is scrappy and unsatisfactory as a whole. But taking the myth's content seriously reveals a very new picture.

After death there is still a sentence pronounced by divine judges, which sends the good to heaven and the bad to punishment (614c2-615c1); there is still a distinction between the curably wicked and the incurable, who are sent forever to Tartarus (615c5-616a7); in all these myths the judgement takes place at a crossroads, where the good and the bad, who have come along the same path, are parted to go to their separate destinations.

But the big and immediate difference in the *Republic* is that there is no longer any suggestion that this is a *final* judgement. What death reveals to Er is that he and everybody else is on a cycle of birth and rebirth (617d6-7). There are now roads coming back from heaven and hell, as prominent as the roads going there (614c1-4). The judges sit in the middle of the openings to these four roads, and there is a constant stream of souls going up or down after their rewards and punishments; this is a constantly ongoing judgement, with none of the finality attaching to the decisions of the solemn judges in the *Gorgias*. The siting of the judgement between the four openings at the somewhat crowded junction where souls pass into and out of lives brings home bluntly the fact that the judgement has shrunk in importance, being now only one episode in a continuing cycle of endless reincarnations.

The rewards and punishments are still to be reckoned with; one pays

tenfold for one's crimes (615a4-c1). So, since anyone has reason to avoid tenfold punishment for what one has done, they still have some significance for the individual. But their significance has been changed by the way that the judgement appears, no longer as a final judgement on my life, but as merely an episode at the end of my life which is part of a cosmic cycle of reincarnations. For there are two very major ways in which my attitude to rewards after death for being just in this life is likely to be affected by the knowledge that Er gains, that my life is only one interlude for a soul on the wheel of reincarnations.

Firstly, my present life is seen in this picture as the result of previous incarnations. As the myth has it, my soul chose my present life because of being in the state resulting from previous lives and their afterlife requitals. And my life and its afterlife upshot will dispose the soul to choose the next. The souls in the myth choose lives mostly (Plato does not say entirely) according to the habits of their former lives (620a2-3); and this is the only way that we can make sense of the choices that are then described for us. Thus, Ajax chooses to be a lion, Epeius to be a craftswoman, and so on; we are clearly not meant to take this entirely seriously, but this is the *kind* of choice that Plato thinks takes place.

However, to the extent that my present life is the product of past lives and their afterlife requitals, it becomes hard for me to think seriously that *I* should be rewarded or punished. A conviction that the responsibility for my character and actions does not go back to me and then stop, but can be traced in large part to previous lives which I do not remember is bound to undercut the feeling that *I* am responsible for what *I* have done. The effect of such a conviction is exactly like that of the conviction that my character and way of life is as it is largely because of the effects of my family and political situation. (Indeed, if we demythologize the myth, this is what we are to be persuaded of by the story about previous lives.) Either way, facts over which I had little or no control, and which lie in the past, are held to be responsible, at least in large part, for what I do and the way I act and think now.

But this idea is a depressing one; the moral quality of my life and the results of this have been determined already by what has gone before, by previous lives I do not remember. And this thought, like a conviction of the truth of more modern kinds of determinism, must tend to paralyze any sense of being truly responsible for being the kind of person one is, and for acting as one does. And together with this, of course, any sense that punishment for what I do and am is fair is bound to wither too. In their allotted role in the Myth of Er, the afterlife punishments are pointless and

cruel (and the rewards correspondingly arbitrary). How can it be right for me to be punished for having been unjust, if my unjust state resulted from factors over which I had little or no control? As personal requital for what *I* have done, punishment has become grossly unfair. It makes sense only if it is itself regarded as part of the cosmic pattern; my treatment after death is then merely inevitable requital for what I have done in life, and its results go on to produce another stage of the cycle. But if the rewards or punishments only make sense when viewed as part of the total pattern, and not from my viewpoint, they cease to have real moral significance for me. They will still be either good or horrible, and therefore to be awaited with anxiety; but there is nothing that I can do that will bring it about that I receive the one rather than the other. Which it will be, has already been decided in and by lives that are already past.

The cycle of reincarnations represents a belief in a kind of determinism. The cosmos in this myth whirls round the spindle of Necessity; the process is regulated by the Fates. The language of the passage is full of references to fate and necessity.²⁶ But the more my life is shown to me as being part of an unending cycle of events over which I have no control, the less I can feel that rewards for being just, or punishments for being unjust, really answer to what I have done and chosen. The Myth of Er, in which the judgement on my life has shrunk to being merely one stage on the fated cycle of rebirths, is less likely to make me rethink my life and choose different priorities than it is to alienate and detach me from my own moral character. If the myth is right, then the proper way to view it is as being in large part the product of factors unavailable to my consciousness and beyond my control, and doomed to end in results which, whether pleasant or the opposite, are merely inevitable responses to the product in me of those factors.

Plato is clearly aware of this problem, for in the middle of the pageant of necessity he suddenly insists that the souls do have a free choice of lives; they are told that they choose their *daimon* or guardian spirit rather than having one allotted and that they, not God, are responsible for their choice (617e1-5). Yet Plato only insists on, and gives no reason for, this abrupt appearance of freedom amidst all the talk of the necessity attaching to the cycle of lives and their rewards and punishments. And in any case he does not meet the problem of my seeing myself as responsible for the way I act. The free choice of the souls between lives can have significance for me only if there is some way in which the free choice of my life by a soul on the cycle of rebirths implies that *within* my life *I* have freedom to choose and so am truly responsible for what I choose to do. Yet this seems not to be the case.

Plato could quite well have suggested that what the souls choose is a character, which is then free to make different choices and develop one way or another. But the suggestions of the passage are all that the souls choose a fully worked-out blueprint. The foolish soul who greedily snatches a tyranny, for example, finds himself fated to eat his children (619b7-c6) and finds this out only when, too late, he reads the small print. A single choice of life, then, seems to rule out any further significant choices within that life; the foolish soul has chosen not just what kind of person he will be but absolutely everything that will happen to him. (We are surely meant to think of Thyestes; and though what happened to him was the result of what he did, what he did was also largely brought about by his belonging to a particular family.) So the soul's freedom to choose my life can be no consolation to me; when I discover that I have eaten my children it will still be something revealed to me by the myth as fated; there was nothing I could have done that would have prevented it, and so though I might accept that afterlife punishment for it was equally fated, I could hardly think of it as being fair return to me for my moral character. (That is not how the events of the House of Atreus are portrayed on the stage.) And the fact that the disaster occurred within a life that was freely chosen by a soul on the cosmic cycle is no use to me, and no consolation either.

The unsatisfactoriness of Plato's position here is further underlined by the fact that, after talking for nine books about being just in the conditions of the ideally just society, he now for the first time stresses the extent to which the hampering factors of actual conditions and contingencies in life affect and constrain one's moral achievement. Socrates' speech at 618c-619b even makes it sound as though everything depends on knowing what will result from the position one happens to be in and the chances one happens to have. This stress on the way that one's choices are constrained by the conditions of one's life can only emphasize the failure of the soul's choice of a life to provide any freedom within that life.²⁷

So, despite Plato's clear unhappiness about it, the result of placing the afterlife judgement within a cycle of reincarnations has been to reveal them as part of a fated cycle of happenings within which it is hard for the individual to retain much sense of responsibility for his or her own life. Correspondingly, the moral role of the rewards and punishments changes. They loom not as something deserved, and thus with the power to make one rethink one's life now, but rather as an implacably allotted bonus or calamity that cannot be avoided.

There is another respect in which the significance of the rewards and punishments shrinks in the Myth of Er. For the rewards of justice are part

of a vast cosmic pattern; but it is not, from the individual's point of view, an optimistic or encouraging pattern. In the *Gorgias* and *Phaedo* myths, there was provision for the curably wicked to escape from their punishment, but there was no suggestion that the rewards were anything but permanent. But in the *Republic* there is traffic down from heaven as well as up from the underworld; heavenly rewards are not permanent, but likewise only a transient part of the cycle. Plato very surprisingly accepts the full implications of this: just as punishment makes the souls sadder but wiser, so that they choose better next time, so heavenly bliss renders the soul careless and liable through inexperience of everyday evils to make worse choices. Most of the souls fresh from heaven (*not* just the unphilosophical ones, as is often assumed) make bad choices just because of their unworldly condition (619a1-3). Thus the notion of a *cycle* of rebirths is being taken very seriously; there is no way in which justice gets to predominate, for the increase in justice in the reformed wicked is offset by a fall into injustice by the innocent good. In the cosmos as a whole, everything balances out, but no individual life makes any lasting impact. My being just, then, is cosmically pointless; for as one soul goes up to heaven another comes down to blunder naively into injustice. The afterlife judgement, then, can no longer serve as a moral rectification to individuals, a guarantee that in the end just people do get their due reward. In the Myth of Er the cosmos is horrifyingly indifferent to individuals' moral achievements, and presents no guarantee at all that those achievements will "in the end" get their due reward and not have been thrown away. We find a much more uncompromising, and to the individual depressing, view of the world than the bland moral optimism claimed so insistently in the *Gorgias* and more mutedly in the *Phaedo*.

The universe as portrayed in the Myth of Er is from the individual's point of view indifferent. This does not mean that Plato now thinks of the cosmos as altogether meaningless. If he did, there would at the least be the sharpest conflict with *Laws* book 10, where cosmologies that make the universe a chance product of purely physical factors without purpose are rejected, indeed persecuted, as being wrong, and wickedly so. The Myth of Er presents not such a universe, but one regulated according to justice. It is crucial, however, that this justice and the supremacy of good are wholly impersonal. The justice and goodness in the workings of the world as a whole are seen in the whole cycle of reincarnations and the subsequent balancing of good and evil to individuals. This justice is not apparent if we limit ourselves to the perspective of one particular life and the prospects for it. In the central books Plato urged would-be philosophers to shed their

partial and limited viewpoints and to seek what is good absolutely and essentially, not merely good from a particular point of view. The workings of goodness and justice in the myth are similarly impersonal and have similar disregard for the merely relative viewpoint of particular individuals. To see this universe as just, we must leave behind our own standpoints, with their attendant individual concerns. It is no surprise, then, that this justice is not convenient or comforting for the individual.²⁸

The impersonal turning of the cosmic wheel can be reconciled with moral optimism if one allows for some individual progress that has no corresponding regress, if some can climb ever higher in rebirths and finally escape from the wheel forever. Now we have seen in the *Phaedo* that the philosopher ultimately escapes the doom of embodiment for good. And in the *Phaedrus* myth this is fully worked out: souls are condemned to the cycle of rebirth, but progress is possible, because the eventual reward of getting off the wheel of rebirths is possible – at least for some, the philosophers. But in the *Republic*, strikingly, this idea is totally absent. At 619d8-e5 Socrates describes the fate of the soul all of whose reincarnations are in philosophical lives; its reward is both to come and go from heaven, without descending to the underworld. But within the myth's cosmic pattern, this is not much of a reward. Even if in some unexplained way a good, innocent soul always avoided a bad choice of life, it is still condemned to endless embodiment, and so there is no final judgement and permanent reward. Life and judgement, life and judgement, keep on coming endlessly round.

It is not merely a modern thought that my life, so interesting to me, becomes cosmically pointless if the reality is that it is only one stage in a cycle of reincarnations.²⁹ In *Aeneid* VI, Aeneas is distressed at the sight of souls having to be re-embodied; Anchises has to reassure him, rather unconvincingly and with the aid of a blend of philosophies, that this does not really contradict the providential ordering of the world for the best.³⁰ Later, Augustine protests violently against belief in reincarnation as rendering us unable to believe fully in God's love for us. Augustine's reaction is especially interesting, because as a Christian he believes in the Last Judgement, and so believes that God's judging us (and in some cases, of course, condemning us to eternal torment) is compatible with God's loving us; yet the thought of reincarnation horrifies him, and it clearly does so because he feels that it removes all significance from the individual's attempts to live well and attain salvation. The cosmic indifference implicit in the cycle of reincarnations idea strikes him as something that the in-

dividual has every reason to reject; for as individuals we cannot but be personally concerned with our own salvation.

For who of the truly religious could endure to hear such words as these? After life has been lived amid so many and so great unhappy circumstances . . . we are to arrive, so we are told, at the vision of God and find bliss in the contemplation of incorporeal light through participation in his unchangeable immortality, which we yearn to attain with a burning passion, only on the condition that we must at some time abandon it. And those who abandon it are then doomed to be hurled from that everlasting life, that truth, that happiness and to be caught in the toils of hellish mortality . . . Further, this has happened and will happen again and again without end at fixed intervals and measures of ages past and future . . . Now who would lend ear to such views as these? Who would believe or tolerate them? . . . How then can they aver that the more each one loves God, the more readily he will arrive at bliss, and yet teach doctrines to make that very love grow cold? Who indeed would not be more careless and lukewarm in his love for someone when he imagines that he will perforce leave him? . . . and this when he has reached, in the perfection of bliss, the fullest knowledge of him of which he is capable? For no one can love loyally even a human friend when he knows that in the future he will be an enemy . . . Truly, nothing is more false or fallacious than that kind of bliss which leaves us either in so great a light of truth ignorant that we shall be wretched or on the highest pinnacle of happiness fearful because we shall be so. For if in the world beyond we are to be ignorant of future misfortune, then our present misery on earth is better informed, since it allows us to know of future bliss. On the other hand, if in the world beyond impending disaster is not to be concealed from us, the soul passes its periods of time more happily in misery than it does in happiness; for in the former case, when the periods are completed, the soul is to be raised to bliss, but in the latter the soul is at the end to come full circle to misery. And thus the prospect that we have in our unhappiness is happy and that which we have in our happiness is unhappy. Consequently, since we suffer present evils here on earth and fear impending evils there in heaven, it is truer to say that we may always be in misery than that we may sometimes be in bliss.³¹

The Myth of Er, then, is pointedly different from the other two; it does not express moral optimism as they do. And consequently, in spite of its immediate context it cannot offer us the kind of consequentialist reason to be just that they do. But though the myth is thus at odds with its immediate context, as I have explained, it is, ironically, better fitted than that context suggests to serve as a symbolic expression of the *Republic's* main moral argument. For the original demand was that justice be shown to benefit the agent both in being the kind of thing it is and for its intrinsic consequences, rewards being left out of account. And the myth gives us a view of the world in which this is the case. Justice has good intrinsic consequences — the afterlife rewards. But these rewards are temporary and from the impersonal, cosmic point of view, from which things are seen as they really are, have little or no significance. We should, then, choose to be just because it

is simply better to have an ordered inner life than an unordered one, better to have a healthy than an unhealthy soul. We make this choice against the background of a world presented by the myth, a world where goodness is not necessarily on our side and in which even the best person never wholly escapes from the tragedies and contingencies of life. We also know that our characters and thus our choices are in large part already formed by factors over which we have little or no control; we believe that everything about us is not wholly determined, but we find it hard to locate freedom meaningfully within our lives, at the points where it matters most. Even in this setting, justice is worth having for what it is.

Although we find reincarnation implausible, and even grotesque, the Myth of Er has more serious moral appeal than the last judgement myth. For we find it plausible that we choose to be good, or not, against the background of a cosmos that is indifferent to individuals' concerns and does not necessarily guarantee rewards for our being just. It is not seriously open to us to espouse the moral optimism expressed in the *Gorgias* and *Phaedo* myths. Nobody but an exceptionally naive or ignorant theist could believe that just individuals will always be rewarded in the end.³² A realistic moral philosophy must start by accepting that individuals' lives do not have point in the world as a whole, and that even if justice does turn out to bring rewards in the end, that cannot be an inducement that has any cogency to an honest and realistic person. If we choose to be just, we must choose justice for itself, in a universe that we recognize to be indifferent rather than benevolent to us as individuals.

V

I have argued that the three myths are distinctively different; the last judgement of the *Gorgias* is confusingly mixed in the *Phaedo* with the idea of reincarnation, which, when it appears full-blown in the *Republic*, gives a very different picture with different implications. The difference between the optimistic stress on the divine judges who will put everything right for us, and the more pessimistic emphasis on the impersonality of the cosmic wheel of birth and rebirth, corresponds to a difference in Plato's moral arguments. In the *Gorgias* Plato insists flatly that justice will bring rewards to the agent in the end, though without giving us any good reason to believe this. In the *Republic*, his thought is more profound; while justice still must pay the agent, it is in a radically rethought way, for it pays by being what it is, by making the agent the kind of person that he or she is. When this is clearly grasped, the guaranteed afterlife reward is no longer needed, and Plato is free to develop the less optimistic, but deeper, thought that our

lives proceed as part of a cosmic pattern indifferent to individuals. In the *Phaedo* we see these ideas in tension; the optimism is officially uppermost, but the depiction of Socrates' death in an uncomprehending world is perhaps pulling Plato to the more profound conception.

Plato is often dismissed as a shallow optimist about the supremacy of goodness in the world.³³ Certainly such a shallow optimism was what descended as "Platonism"; a belief in Benevolent Providence, to set against atheists' and Epicureans' denial that things are providentially arranged for the best.³⁴ And certainly Plato's "official" cosmology in the *Timaeus* is a shallowly Providential one. But if my argument is right, his thought on this matter was not fixed, but complex and shifting. He is obviously pulled towards the last judgement myth. But he is also pulled towards the idea that we are all on a cycle of reincarnations; and we have seen that the implications of this are very different. Whatever the idea originally meant to the Pythagoreans from whom Plato probably got it, it represents in Plato a break, at least in one dialogue, from the moral demand that heavenly rewards compensate those who are unjustly treated here in a way that is final and gives an ultimate answer to problems over justice. In the *Timaeus* reincarnation reappears in a Providential setting (and a particularly crass one at that: 91d-92b) and in the *Phaedrus* it is combined with confidence that virtue will be rewarded by ultimate release from the conditions of human life. But in the *Republic* the myth (despite its context) contains no optimistic promise of final reward to induce us to be just. It is fitting that Plato's deepest and most interesting eschatological myth should end the dialogue in which he takes most seriously the question, What, apart from its rewards, shows the life of virtue to be worth possessing?³⁵

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NOTES

¹ Including the following: J. A. Stewart, *The Myths of Plato* (London, Macmillan, 1905); P. Frutiger, *Les Mythes de Platon* (Paris, Alcan, 1930); P. Stöcklein, *Über die philosophische Bedeutung von Platons Mythen*, *Philologus Supplementband XXX Heft 3*, Leipzig 1937; P.-M. Schuhl, *Études sur la fabulation platonicienne* (Paris, Presses Universitaires de France, 1947); L. Edelstein, "The Function of the Myth in Plato's Philosophy", *Journal of the History of Ideas* X (1949) pp. 463-481; K. Reinhardt, "Platons Mythen", pp. 219-295 of *Vermächtnis der Antike - Gesammelte Essays zur Philosophie und Geschichtsschreibung*, ed. C. Becker (Göttingen, Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1960); P. Friedländer, *Plato, an Introduction*, trans. H. Meyerhoff (New York, Harper & Row 1958) ch. IX; J. M. Rist, *Eros and Psyche*, *Phoenix Supplement* vol 6 (University of Toronto, 1964) pp. 7-15; R. Wright, "How credible are Plato's myths?", pp. 364-371 of

Arktouros, *Hellenic Studies presented to Bernard Knox*, ed. G. W. Bowersock et al. (Berlin, New York, de Gruyter, 1979); S. G. Pembroke, "Myth", pp. 301-324 of *The Legacy of Greece*, ed. M. I. Finley (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1981); R. Zaslavsky, *Platonic Myth and Platonic Writing* (Washington, University Press of America, 1981).

² I. M. Crombie, *An Examination of Plato's Doctrines* vol I (London, Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1962) p. 154.

³ I am speaking of a general trend; there have of course been noteworthy exceptions. I have found Stöcklein's monograph helpful in its perception of the points at which philosophical difficulty arises in the interpretation of the three myths I deal with. I have also been helped in general approach by an outstandingly interesting (as yet unpublished) paper on the *Phaedrus* myth by M. F. Burnyeat.

⁴ Pp. 155 ff of "Plato and Politics: the *Critias* and the *Politicus*", *Phronesis* XXIV (1979) pp. 148-167. Cf. also C. Gill, "The Origin of the Atlantis myth", *Trivium* 11, pp. 1-11.

⁵ This is stressed by Zaslavsky, and by Pembroke, pp. 301-2.

⁶ Cf. *Republic* 377a4-c5, 522a7-8; *Timaeus* 23b3-5; *Laws* 841c6-7, 887d2 ff; *Cratylus* 408c8; *Philebus* 14a3-4; *Hippias Major* 286a1-2; *Sophist* 242c8-9; *Politicus* 268e4-5, 304c10-d2.

⁷ Allegorizing is rejected at *Republic* 378d3-e1; explanation in terms of physical theory at *Phaedrus* 229c4-230a6.

⁸ Interesting here is the criticism made by the Epicurean Colotes preserved by Proclus, and Proclus' reply to it (*in Rem Publ.* 105.23-106.14 Kroll). One of Colotes' complaints was that Plato is inconsistent to use myths himself after attacking the poets' use of eschatological myth. Proclus (106.23-6) says that Plato did not reject all *mythologia*, but only the kind written by Homer and Hesiod, τὴν διὰ τῶν αἰσχροῦν καὶ ἀθέσμων πλασμάτων χωροῦσαν.

⁹ *Laws* 645b1-8, 872d7-e5; *Republic* 501e2-5. Protagoras is indifferent as to whether he gives a *mythos* or *logos* (*Protagoras* 320c2 ff, 324d6-7, 328c3-4) and his theory of perception is called a *mythos* at *Theaetetus* 165c4-5 and 164d8-e4. There may be irony in both these cases, though.

¹⁰ *Timaeus* 29d2-3, 59c6, 68d2.

¹¹ *Republic* 501e2-5.

¹² Cf. *Gorgias* 527a5-b2, *Republic* 621b8-c1, *Phaedo* 114d1-7, *Laws* 645b1-8.

¹³ On the status of this myth, which is introduced, in the *Timaeus* and *Critias*, in a very strange fashion, see C. Gill, "Plato's Atlantis Story and the Birth of Fiction", *Philosophy and Literature* 3 (1979) pp. 64-78, especially pp. 71-77; and "The Genre of the Atlantis Story", *Classical Philology* 72 (1979) pp. 287-304.

¹⁴ *Gorgias* 523a1-3, 524a8-b2, 526d3-4, 527a5-b2.

¹⁵ Plotinus, commenting on Plato's *Symposium* myth, says that myth relates as separate what is not so in reality; understanding a myth is coming to see as simultaneously the case what the myth relates as distinct and successive events. However, Plotinus at once adds, this is true of *logoi* or reasoned discourses also: they talk of things happening which cannot in reality happen or change. (*Enneads* III, 5, 9. For application of this point to his own arguments, cf. IV, 3,9; IV, 8,4; V, 1,6.) For NeoPlatonic interpretations of myths (both Homeric and Platonic) as metaphysical truths, cf. A. Sheppard, *Studies on the 5th and 6th Essays of Proclus' Commentary on the Republic*, esp. chs 2 and 4 (*Hypomnemata* Heft 61, Göttingen, Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1980). The NeoPlatonists are, however, of limited interest from the present point of view, since they mostly treat Platonic myths simply as allegories of a complicated kind.

¹⁶ D. Gallop, *Plato's Phaedo* (Oxford, Clarendon Press, Clarendon Plato Series, 1975) p. 224, note on 114d1-115a3.

¹⁷ See the excellent note on this passage by Dodds (Plato, *Gorgias*, Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1959) pp. 372-6. On the sources for the eschatological myths see also Frutiger, pp. 249-265.

¹⁸ Cf. 452e-453a, 454e-455a, 486a-c, 508c-511c, 521a-522e. The contrast has already been suggested at *Apology* 41a-b.

¹⁹ From the end of the 1st edition of *The Methods of Ethics*; quoted by J. L. Mackie in "Sidgwick's Pessimism", *Philosophical Quarterly* 26 (1976), pp. 317-327. A different passage from Sidgwick is quoted by T. Irwin on pp. 249-250 of his *Plato, Gorgias* (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1979). Stöcklein's comment on this myth is also of interest: "Fingieren wir einen Kosmos ohne die ausgleichende jenseitige Gerechtigkeit! Ein furchtbarer Mißklang würde ihn zerreißen. Für Platon aber scheidet diese Möglichkeit aus . . . Und nicht nur ein Mißklang würde alle Ordnung sprengen; der Ernst der Werte, den wir fühlen, wäre eine bloße Fassade, ihre Forderung an uns eine ironische Vexierung. Dann würde man für die Werte *nicht* sterben können!" (pp. 22-3)

²⁰ As well as the argument quoted (pp. 303, 375, 380-1) Dodds has two other grounds. He thinks (p. 381) that the unfairness implicit in the fact that it is harder for the powerful to resist wickedness than the powerless (525d-526b) requires balancing in future lives. But Plato is not trying to produce a general theodicy, morally justifying everything about the way the world is now. Dodds also finds reincarnation implied at 493c3, in the myth of the water-carriers; but Plato regards this as a "Sicilian or Italian" philosophical myth (493a5-6); he need not be committing himself to it, and it may not be insignificant that its application is found unconvincing.

²¹ Compare the *Somnium Scipionis*, where Scipio is amazed by the smallness of the earth (and of human achievements) when he sees its place in the whole universe.

²² The passage is at 81e-82b. Reincarnation is implied by the conclusion of the Cyclical Argument — at least by what Plato takes to be proved by that (71d14-e2). But since that argument patently does not prove *personal* immortality, it does not serve as a direct source of Plato's commitment to reincarnation.

²³ 248d-249d. The *Phaedrus* myth is clearly relevant to my argument, but I shall refer to it only to elucidate the myths which are my present concern, where the afterlife appears in a context of *judgement*, forcing the individual to think of himself or herself as judged for the way they are living now.

²⁴ Gallop (p. 224) comments that the myth would not be likely to charm away the fear of death from anyone, rather the reverse, "unless his conscience was unusually clear". But Socrates is representing himself as just such a person: one of many indications that the death of Socrates is not portrayed in a biographically accurate way, but rather in a way meant to represent the death of the perfect philosopher who has ceased to identify with the body.

²⁵ Including myself in the past (pp. 349-353 of *An Introduction to Plato's Republic* (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1981)). My remarks there on the myth now seem to me too simple and in parts confused.

²⁶ 616c4, 617b4, b7-c1, e1-2, 618b3, 619c1, 620d6-621a1.

²⁷ It has been put to me forcefully by Christopher Gill and Colin Macleod that free choice within a life may well be a secondary matter here for Plato: what interests him is the choice *of* life — a theme stressed in book 2 and emerging in book 10 in the apostrophe to Glaucon. If so, Plato may here be limiting his attention to such fundamental choices

and assuming, rather than denying, freedom in everyday matters of decision. I agree that I have not dealt adequately here with the way the myth gives us a metaphor of the fundamental choice between ways of life with which we are always faced, and the way both the need for and the difficulty of such a choice are emphasized. I remain convinced, however, that the problem of freedom in everyday choices does remain, and that Plato's discussion here, deliberately or not, does to a large extent remove our freedom in such matters and with it our sense of responsibility for being the way we are. It would have been easy to give examples that did not do this, instead of the Thyestes-like tyrant.

²⁸ There is here, I think, a striking analogy with the doctrine of "the eternal recurrence" found in the Stoics and in Nietzsche. The idea that my life will recur infinitely many times, but with no differences from my life now, makes my individual strivings cosmically pointless and absurd. 'Let us think this thought in its most terrible form: existence as it is, without meaning or aim, yet recurring inevitably without any finale of nothingness: "the eternal recurrence"' (Nietzsche, *The Will to Power* section 55). The belief is represented as a repellent one; it is the black snake that has crawled into the sleeping shepherd's mouth and bitten fast, and accepting it is as hard and repellent as biting the snake's head off (*Thus Spoke Zarathustra* III "On the Vision and the Riddle" and "The Convalescent"). I find very plausible the view of A. Nehamas ("the Eternal Recurrence", *Philosophical Review* LXXXIX (1980), pp. 331-356) that Nietzsche is interested not in cosmology but in the thought that if my life were to recur, *nothing* about it could be at all different; a life dissimilar in any way would not be *my* life. This is a thought we shrink from; only the ideal Superman can so totally accept himself as he is, rather than indulging in the fancy that in many ways he might have been different. I am inclined to think that the Stoic belief is likewise better seen as such a moral claim rather than a silly and fanciful cosmology. Certainly as a physical doctrine it is exposed to the objection put forcefully by Jonathan Barnes ("La doctrine du retour éternel", pp. 3-20 of *Les Stoiciens et leur logique*, ed. J. Brunschwig, Actes du colloque de Chantilly, 1976 (Paris, Vrin, 1978)): the Stoics cannot even distinguish *different* lives to recur. For, distinguishing times only by the events happening at times, they cannot consistently say that *the same* events recur at different times: for one and the same event to recur eternally is just for it to occur once. But this seems to me an advantage, not a defect: the physical "theory" appears as merely a vivid way of putting the point that, appearances to the contrary, nothing whatsoever in my life is contingent, for if my life were to occur again it would all be *exactly* the same — a life different in the least particular would not be my life. This notion has definite psychological implications for the way I view my life, and they are far from comforting to the ordinary individual. The Stoic sage, of course, will calmly accept this truth, as will the Superman; but none of us have the detachment required, and to us the idea is merely depressing and frightening.

²⁹ Richard Sorabji, to whom I owe the Augustine quotation below, has told me that in his study of ancient views of time and death he has found no pagan holding (against the Christian view put forward by Augustine) that the cycle of reincarnations idea is comforting or should raise optimism.

³⁰ *Aeneid* VI, 703-751. (I owe the reference to Christopher Gill). Cf. R. Arundel, "Principio Caelum: *Aeneid* vi, 724-751", *Proceedings of the Vergil Society* 3 (1963-4) pp. 27-34; R. D. Williams, "The 6th Book of the *Aeneid*", *Greece and Rome* XI (1964) pp. 48-63, esp. 57-8. Vergil follows the *Phaedrus* myth in allowing a few purified souls to escape from the cycle of rebirths, but the point is made very obscurely.

³¹ *City of God* XII 21, transl P. Levine (Loeb Classical Library).

³² Lest this seem too dismissive, I should add that I do not think that the belief that the last judgement myth expresses an important religious truth is necessarily naive; what is naive is the belief that this gives a satisfactory *moral* answer to the problems raised by the flourishing of evil in the world. Dostoyevsky, in the Grand Inquisitor passage, is one of many Christians who have clearly separated the two ideas (not, of course, that he is a good example of a theist).

³³ This is, of course, quite different from optimism about the sovereignty of good in the ideal world of the Forms; we would not even expect our world to display that unambiguously.

³⁴ I have in mind (I hope not unfairly) the Middle Platonists; Plotinus' discussion of Providence (*Enneads* III 2-3) while not ultimately satisfactory, can hardly be called shallow.

³⁵ I am very grateful for helpful discussion and criticism of an earlier draft from Jonathan Barnes, Myles Burnyeat, Christopher Gill, Colin Macleod, Rosemary Wright, and the audience at a meeting of the Cambridge "B" Club.